

to different consumer bases. Hero has a knack of expanding the market, [and] reaching more customers,” Munjal said. “The market has been in continuous expansion and we are bringing a unique value proposition to the table.”

Further, the HD X440 is Harley’s most affordable bike in India, priced at ₹2.29 lakh.

Then there’s Triumph, which launched its most affordable bikes—developed in partnership with Bajaj Auto—in India, in the same week. The Speed 400 was launched at ₹2.33 lakh, and the Scrambler 400 X at an undisclosed price. “We are hopeful of [achieving] significant volumes,” said Rajiv Bajaj, MD of Bajaj Auto, at the launch. Bajaj and Triumph had started talking about it back in 2007. “These motorcycles are the smallest-capacity and most affordable ones by Triumph.”

While Bajaj is not new to the premium bikes segment (it sells premium bikes under the KTM brand, and its Dominar motorcycles), Sumeet Narang, President of Probiking Business (KTM and Triumph) at Bajaj Auto, says Triumph is going to be instrumental in the company’s premium segment play. “With all our brands, whether it is KTM or Triumph, we would be providing customers many alternative propositions. I wouldn’t call it a challenge [when it comes to Royal Enfield]. The way the market trends are moving, our products would be relevant.”

But experts say it will be difficult to beat Royal Enfield’s brand loyalty and leadership. “Although original equipment manufacturers are trying to transition to premium- and mid-size segments, Royal Enfield is the strongest brand there. Going forward, the competition will intensify for them, and this space is also becoming crowded,” says Welekar. While competition will definitely heat up, will brand value be enough to attract buyers and chip away at the dominance of Royal Enfield? Seems unlikely.

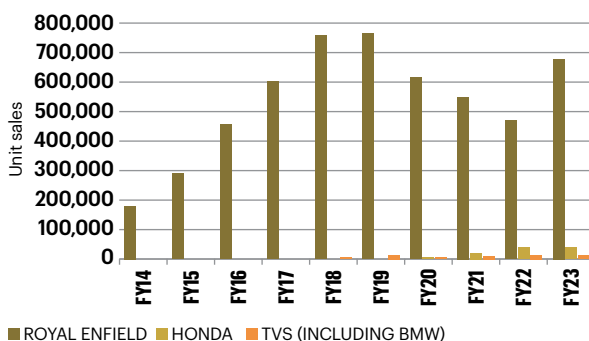
Yogesh Mathur, Director of Sales and Marketing at Honda Motorcycle & Scooter India (HMSI), says the company is gaining numbers in the premium motorcycle market in India with its strong product line-up from bikes in the 300-1,800cc segment. “Considering the strong demand and rapid shift towards premium motorcycles, HMSI will be introducing new models, including in the mid-size segment.” The company aims to expand its reach

ROAD RUSH

While Royal Enfield has stolen a march in every segment of the premium bikes market, competitors are now trying to play catch-up

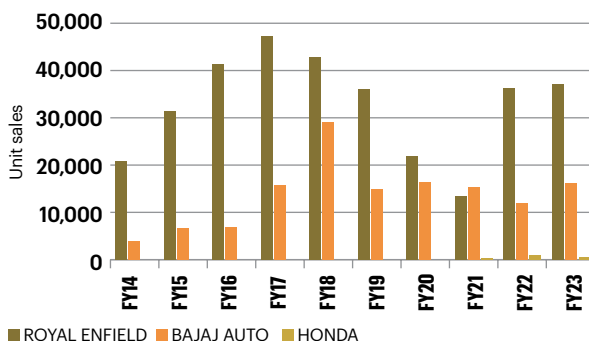
ENGINE CAPACITY

250 TO 350CC



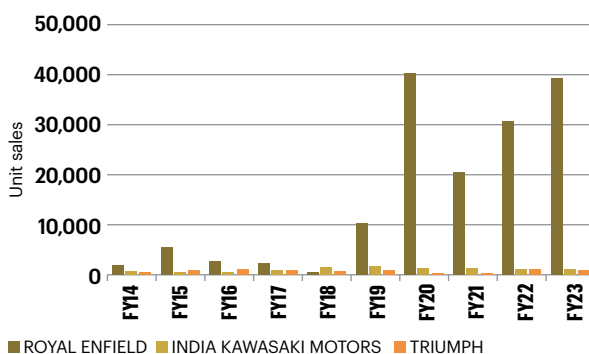
ENGINE CAPACITY

350 TO 500CC



ENGINE CAPACITY

500 TO 800CC



TOP 3 PLAYERS IN THE PREMIUM BIKES SEGMENT;
SOURCE: SIAM